

CORE FORMULA

Their word + "how?" — "Weird how?" / "Intense how?" / "Messy how?" -> Small comment first — "That sounds like the important word. Intense how?" -> Meaning check — "When you say 'freeing', what do you mean?" -> Two options — "Good-weird or bad-weird?" / "Exciting-intense or stressful-intense?" -> For a decision — "When you say 'risky', is the concern timing, cost, or quality?"

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Pick the word carrying the most emotional charge and ask "[word] how?" — "Weird how?", "Intense how?", "Messy how?", "Freeing how?"

BEST FOR

- Someone uses a vague but charged descriptor — "weird", "messy", "intense", "complicated", "freeing", "awkward", "surprisingly good".
- The conversation is drifting and you want a simple way to deepen it.
- You want the other person to keep talking without a broad, generic question.
- Someone hints at emotion but does not fully spell it out.
- Networking, dating, social conversation, leadership, coaching, conflict-softening and understanding before persuasion.
- Digital or text conversations where a short follow-up keeps momentum: "Good-weird or bad-weird?"

PHRASE BANK

Quick openers · One-line "how?" follow-ups

- "Weird how?"
- "Intense how?"
- "Messy how?"
- "Complicated how?"
- "Awkward how?"
- "Different how?"
- "Unexpected how?"
- "Good-different or bad-different?"

Warm / connecting · Noticing the word with warmth

- "That word sounds like it carries a bit. What made it feel that way?"
- "You said 'intense' like there's a story there. Intense how?"
- "That sounds like the important word. What made it complicated?"
- "When you say it was 'strange', what was strange about it?"
- "I'm curious about the word you used there. What made it feel messy?"

Social / dating · Playful, charismatic openers

- "That sentence is doing a lot of work. 'Weird' how?"
- "Okay, 'surprisingly good' needs unpacking."
- "You can't say 'wild' and then just move on."
- "You said 'weirdly fun'. I like that phrase. Weirdly how?"
- "Good-chaos or absolutely-not-chaos?"
- "What kind of 'different' do you mean?"
- "That sounds like a story hiding in one word."

- "When you say 'I'm particular', particular how?"

Professional / leadership · Clarifying the word for a decision

- "When you say 'risky', what risk are you most concerned about?"
- "You called it 'messy'. Is that a people issue, a process issue, or a timing issue?"
- "When you say 'not aligned', where exactly is the mismatch?"
- "You said 'unclear'. What part needs clarifying first?"
- "What makes this feel more complicated than it looks?"

Conflict-softening · Defusing a charged word

- "You said it felt 'dismissive'. What made it land that way?"
- "When you say 'unfair', what part feels most unfair?"
- "That word matters. What felt disrespectful about it?"
- "You used 'pressure'. Where did the pressure come from?"
- "I don't want to assume. What does 'not heard' mean from your side?"

Digital / text · Short follow-ups that keep momentum

- "Good-weird or bad-weird?"
- "Good-intense or bad-intense?"
- "What made it feel messy?"
- "When you say 'off', what felt off?"
- "That word seems important. What do you mean by it?"
- "Complicated in a practical way or emotional way?"

High-status / busy person · Cutting straight to the constraint

- "When you say 'risky', which risk should I prioritise?"
- "What part feels least workable?"
- "Where's the real constraint?"
- "What makes that the key issue?"
- "What does 'too slow' mean in practical terms?"

Shy / guarded person · Low-pressure invitations with an exit

- "No pressure to go into it, but when you say 'weird', what kind of weird?"
- "Only if you want to unpack it — complicated how?"
- "Was it more awkward or more frustrating?"
- "What part of it felt most off?"
- "You don't have to explain the whole thing — I'm just curious what you meant by 'intense'."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Uses the technique mechanically or too often.
Better: Uses the smallest useful version, then listens.
Best: Uses it only when the cue is present, keeps the wording natural, and adjusts to the response.
2. Weak: Talks about the technique instead of doing it.
Better: Performs one clear behavioural move.
Best: Makes the move feel like ordinary skilled conversation.

DECISION TREE

If They elaborate warmly

Reflect the meaning, then ask one more follow-up or contribute something of your own.
"So it was less about the work and more about the people."

If They answer briefly

Do not push. Comment lightly or move on.
"Fair enough — sounds like one of those days."

If They seem guarded

Give them an exit rather than pressing.

"No pressure if you'd rather leave it there."

If They correct you

Accept the correction and adjust your read.

"Got it — not intense, more uncertain."

If They become vulnerable

Slow down, validate, and avoid humour too early.

"That sounds like it actually mattered."

If They get defensive

Back off the interpretation and validate.

"Fair — I may be over-reading one word."

SCENARIOS

Casual conversation — they say "It was weirdly intense."

Echo the charged word, then reflect their answer before adding your own experience. — "Weirdly intense how?"

Networking — they say "It's been a messy year for the industry."

Offer a two-option version so they can point at what they mean. — "Messy in what way — people, funding, or direction?"

Workplace influence — they say "The plan feels risky."

Clarify the word toward a decision rather than debating it. — "When you say risky, which risk should we solve first?"

Conflict — they say "That felt dismissive."

Name that you don't want to assume, then let them define the word. — "I don't want to assume. What made it feel dismissive?"

Dating / social — they say "That trip was chaotic but fun."

Play with a light two-option question to keep the energy up. — "Good-chaotic or never-again chaotic?"

Digital / text — they text "Today was weird."

Keep it to one short line so it's easy to answer. — "Good-weird or bad-weird?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- They are giving short answers, rushed, distracted, or clearly not interested in expanding.
- The word is too private, painful or sensitive for the depth of the relationship.
- Your tone might sound sceptical, mocking or cross-examining.
- You have already used it several times and it is starting to feel like a technique.
- They need a direct answer, a decision, or practical help rather than more exploration.
- You are using the word as "evidence" to prove your interpretation rather than inviting their meaning.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Notice the word

In every real conversation today, silently spot the one charged word — weird, messy, intense, freeing — without acting on it. Just train your ear.

Day 2 — Rehearse the move

Say the minimum viable move out loud three times: pick a charged word and ask "[word] how?" — "Weird how?", "Intense how?", "Messy how?" Make it sound casual, not clever.

Day 3 — One follow-up, live

Use exactly one loaded-word follow-up in each conversation so it never feels mechanical, then let them define the word without helping.

Day 4 — Convert every "why?"

Turn "Why?" into "What made it [word]?" Rewrite three recent "why" questions this way and use one for real.

Day 5 — Two-option versions

Practise the two-option form: "good-weird or bad-weird?", "task issue or people issue?", "exciting-intense or stressful-intense?"

Day 6 — Reflect, then contribute

After each follow-up, add a one-line reflection or a small thought of your own so it stays a conversation, not an interview.

Day 7 — Practise the repair

Deliberately over-ask once, then use a recovery line — "That came out like an interrogation; I was just curious about the word you used" — and note how the repair lands.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I pick a word with real energy, not just a random adjective?
- Did my tone sound curious rather than sceptical?
- Did I ask one short follow-up instead of stacking questions?
- Did I let them define the word rather than interpreting it for them?
- Did I reflect or contribute after one or two follow-ups?
- Did I stop when they gave short or guarded answers?